iconographic examinations of these significant physical traces, comparing them with more firmly dated examples. This fresh perspective does much to reveal the world of the pre-imperial Shansabanis and other Ghuris, and the effects of this early existence on the Shansabanis' later imperial identities.

For our purposes of attaining a glimpse of the geographical and cultural beginnings of the Shansabanis during the eleventh–mid-twelfth centuries – that is, prior to and around the time of their emergence into the "history" conveyed by the textual sources – it is important to focus on their principal geographic vectors of activity within present-day Afghanistan. These vectors were of course initially concentrated in the heartland of Ghur, geographically delimited and architecturally analyzed below. But, as described in Chapter 1, it is worth bearing in mind that by the 1150s, the Bamiyan valley to the east was the site of an established collateral Shansabani lineage, while the Firuzkuh Shansabanis had also pushed far southward to Tiginabad/Old Qandahar, beyond what were likely their ancestral over-wintering areas in southern Ghur-Zamindawar (see Chapter 3). Then, by the later 1160s, Shansabani presence was documentable northwest of historical Ghur in the region of Maimana (Badghis Province) and northeastward toward Balkh, firmly within the historical geography of greater Khurasan. By the 1180s, Shansabani control had extended westward from Ghur to include Herat and its vicinity. All of these expansions and their architectural footprints will be discussed in the following chapters.

Ghur

In current political maps, historical Ghur (map, p. xvi) is surrounded by the contiguous provinces of Farah, Herat, and Badghis on its western flank; Faryab and Sar-i Pul to the north; Bamiyan, Daykundi, and Uruzgan along the eastern flank; and Farah and Helmand provinces to the south. Ghur Province itself comprises ten districts named according to their more prominent towns. These districts appear to be much more spacious and less numerous than the tiny and multiplied divisions of the eastern provinces of Kabul, Logar, and Nangarhar, for example – no doubt reflecting the great differences in population density among these regions of the country in modern times.

This seemingly ordered landscape of the present varied greatly in the past. The deeply carved terrain in much of Ghur makes satellite data difficult to use without on-the-ground verification.[15] And the interventions in the built environment resulting from the Mongol campaigns of the second and third quarters of the thirteenth century may have erased many indices of populations inhabiting Ghur's mountainous lands, further